# Plato - Justice, Knowledge and Power

Plato's *Republic* is arguably one of the greatest achievements of Western philosophy and literature, and a high point of both ancient political thought and Platonism. Its first book deserves special attention. It introduces themes that the remaining nine books will develop, but it also has a certain unity of its own. Some scholars have conjectured that it began as a separate dialogue called *Thrasymachus* and was later reworked. Whether or not that is true, Book I has the character of a self-contained drama and of an opening movement. Like a symphony, it states themes that will be elaborated and brought back at the end. The first scene is a microcosm of the whole.

Socrates narrates the dialogue to an unidentified audience. He begins by saying that he went down to the Piraeus. The words "up" and "down" acquire philosophical weight in the divided line and the allegory of the cave in Books VI and VII. Down is where it is dark. In the opening descent, one can already see the philosopher coming down among the people, as the philosopher-ruler will have to do. The Piraeus was the port of Athens, a place of shipping, foreign residents and contact with the outside world. It was a democratic stronghold.

Socrates and Glaucon go there to pray and to see a festival. They are both worshippers and spectators, theorists in an older Greek sense of the word. After watching the procession and the rites, they start back up towards the city. In the symbolism of the dialogue this can be read as a move towards philosophical understanding. Glaucon is, in my view, the most impressive of the interlocutors. But just as the two are about to leave, an enslaved boy sent by Polemarchus tells them to wait. Glaucon agrees. Polemarchus, whose father Cephalus also knows Socrates, catches up with them in the company of several others.

Polemarchus points out how many they are and how few Socrates and Glaucon are. Either prove stronger, he says, or stay with us. Here is the basic tension between power and knowledge. Those with superior numbers have the power, and the philosopher, who might know something they do not, is at their mercy. Socrates asks whether there is another possibility: might he persuade them to let him go? Polemarchus asks whether they could persuade people who refuse to listen. That reply is worth keeping in mind when reading the *Apology* and thinking about Socrates' death. The philosopher is at once a part of the city and an outsider in the city of his birth.

Socrates would rather go back up. Yet Book VII will make the philosopher go back down for the benefit of the city. In the opening scene, force takes the place of a moral obligation, though the two point in the same direction. Glaucon makes the decision to stay for both of them. On this reading, the people who decide in a badly ordered city are not necessarily those who know best. The group almost turns spontaneously into a democracy, with numbers determining the outcome. Polemarchus begins as a kind of democratic man. The relation between the character of a city and the character of a person will become one of the book's main themes. It is already being established here. You cannot really read the *Republic* for the first time, I tell my students, until you have read it twice or three times. The opening pages are especially worth returning to.

At the house they find Cephalus, a very old man who has been offering a sacrifice and still wears a ceremonial wreath. He warmly greets Socrates and remarks that they seldom see him in the Piraeus. A philosopher among the people is an unusual sight. This matters in a dialogue whose narrator will be condemned by democratic Athens. A person who claims to know more than others does not stand to them simply as an equal. There is a fundamental tension between philosophy and the democratic city.

Socrates asks what it is like to grow old. Cephalus is a generation ahead of him and has experience that the younger men can learn from. Old age, Cephalus says, is bearable, especially with money and a decent character. As one can read him, he has known the attractions of sex, wine, wealth and power. He is a prosperous resident foreigner who has spent his life in business. He is an erotic man in the broad sense that he has been pulled by desires, not just sexual ones. On this reading, pleasure was his measure of a good life, and he was not always scrupulous about how he got what he wanted. Now that death is near, he begins to take seriously the stories about Hades that he once laughed at. Contemplating death makes him wonder whether the gods have been keeping account of his actions.

Money can help him make amends. He can pay back what he owes to people and provide the sacrifices he owes to the gods. Put less charitably, he can settle with the people he has cheated and try to bribe the gods. It is rather like a get-out-of-jail-free card in Monopoly, except that what he hopes to get out of is Hades. That comparison captures the conventional, almost commercial piety that I see in Cephalus.

Cephalus approves a remark by Sophocles. Asked in old age whether he could still have sex, Sophocles said he was glad to have escaped a harsh and cruel master. For Cephalus, the lessening of desire makes it easier to live decently with oneself and others. His conscience can have more of a say now that his strength is failing, although that is a rather different thing from having learned to govern his desires when they were strong. The joke points to something central in the *Republic*: the organisation and direction of desire. The love of sex, knowledge, power or honour shapes different kinds of souls and, correspondingly, different regimes. When Cephalus says that he now likes conversation more than he did before, one can imagine Socrates thinking how much more useful that would have been twenty, thirty or forty years earlier. Socrates, of course, does not say it.

Instead, he asks about the connection between justice and wealth. Cephalus sees in wealth a means of avoiding wrong to people and dishonour to the gods. He finds it hard to imagine a person being both poor and virtuous, though Socrates himself is worth considering as a counterexample. He treats justice as telling the truth and giving back what is owed. Those are plausible parts of justice, but the definition is limited. Suppose I borrow a weapon from someone who later goes mad. Must I return it to him then? Socrates chooses his examples to suit his interlocutors. Here even a man concerned with his own safety can see what is wrong with the rule. Give the man back his sword and he might kill you with it.

Cephalus leaves to attend to the sacrifices, and Polemarchus becomes heir to the argument as he is heir to his father’s property. Cephalus stands for ancestral piety, which is neither wholly corrupt nor adequate as a moral guide. He should be allowed to go with respect. But the inquiry has to move beyond established custom and religious

ceremony. It passes from an old man who is unlikely to change to a young one who still can.

Polemarchus first appeals to Simonides. If the poet is to be believed, justice is giving what is due. Socrates asks what that means. Polemarchus takes it to mean helping friends and harming enemies. The appeal to a poet is significant. Once established religious convention has left the scene, the next thing the argument must get beyond is appeal to authority. Eventually Polemarchus has to speak in his own name and think through what he owes other people.

First Socrates asks when justice is useful. Polemarchus suggests partnerships and contracts. But a skill that enables one to keep wealth safe might also enable one to steal it. Being good at performing a contract would not by itself explain why one should perform it justly. Nor is it obvious that our friends and enemies are who we think they are. Polemarchus has to reconsider his answer. It is a step forward when he stops taking refuge behind Simonides.

Socrates asks what it means to harm someone. If we harm a horse, we make it worse in the excellence proper to a horse. The Greek word *aretē* can mean either virtue or excellence. Good horsemanship cultivates a horse's excellence as a horse, not the excellence of a table or a sheep. Likewise, doing harm to human beings makes them worse in human excellence. A just person, acting justly, cannot make others less just. Socrates concludes that it is not the work of a good person to harm anyone, whether friend or enemy.

In one sense the good person has no enemies. Others may be hostile to Socrates, but he tries to benefit them just as he benefits his friends. Thrasymachus sees himself as Socrates' antagonist. Socrates later says that they have become friends although they were never enemies. The benefit Socrates has in mind is education, because virtue is bound up with knowledge. To improve people through dialectic is to give them what they are due. It is also what piety means to Socrates: serving the god by helping one's fellow human beings.

The argument has Christian overtones for a later reader, but Socrates reaches it through a conception of justice rather than through a mystical obligation. Being just makes a person genuinely social; being wholly unjust separates a person from society. In a sense Socrates is the most social of men because he recognises educational obligations to all. He is already acting on that conviction in his exchange with Polemarchus. He asks the young man to stop quoting authorities and think for himself. Teaching him to do this is the very benefit that, in Socrates' view, one owes others.

At this point Thrasymachus attacks. Plato compares him to a wild animal. On this reading he is the sophist and the tyrannical man, who thinks that the more desires he gratifies, the better off he is. He is the spiritual opposite of Socrates, who becomes a philosophical lion-tamer. Socrates may not refute him altogether, but he does enough damage to the argument to silence him. That distinction matters. In my view the sophists' pursuit of pure power and private gratification tends towards nihilism, and nihilism tends towards silence. An observation of Wittgenstein's helps explain why: language is something we share. If one tries to isolate oneself morally, politically and linguistically, discourse breaks down. The sophist prefers rhetoric and long speeches to the give and take of dialectic, which requires a community of speakers.

Thrasymachus demands that Socrates give a concrete answer. Do not tell us that justice is the useful, the helpful or the advantageous, he says. Tell us specifically what it is. He has little patience for Platonic abstraction. With exceptions like Hippias, sophists are rarely interested in mathematics. Their interests are more tangible: tables and chairs, political power, the satisfaction of immediate desires. Socrates retreats with irony. He professes incompetence and praises Thrasymachus' wisdom. Instead of rushing to attack, he lets his opponent make the first move. It is usually easier to defend a position than to attack head-on.

For Thrasymachus, speech is a Homeric contest. He wants Socrates to speak first so that he can tear the answer apart. Both men seek a kind of heroism, but they mean different things by it. Suppose I can give a better answer about justice, Thrasymachus says. What should you suffer? Socrates says that he should suffer what every ignorant person should suffer: he should learn. What appears to be a penalty is a benefit. Thrasymachus demands money as well. This brings out a contrast. The sophist speaks for his own reputation and payment. Socrates speaks for his hearers and does not charge for it.

Socrates offers to pay when he has the money, which is doubly ironic given his poverty and refusal to charge. Glaucon, characteristically courageous and a little impetuous, promises that he and his friends will put up the money. Now speak, Thrasymachus. Money talks, and so does Thrasymachus. Justice, he declares, is the advantage of the stronger.

The claim belongs in the same intellectual world as Thucydides' Melian Dialogue and the power politics of the Peloponnesian War. On this view, politics has winners and losers, and moral law does not govern it. There are anticipations here of Machiavelli and Nietzsche, and, in a more qualified way, Hobbes. For Socrates, by contrast, politics is ethics writ large. For Thrasymachus the actual regime in each city makes laws in its own interest. Justice consists in obeying those laws. In this respect his position resembles legal positivism: what counts as just depends on who has the power to legislate, and different regimes accordingly prescribe different kinds of justice.

Thrasymachus would like to leave with his money and the admiration of his listeners. Socrates asks him to stay and submit his claim to dialectical examination. What if rulers mistake their own interests, as people frequently do? When they enact laws that actually work against their advantage, obedience would be both just, because it is obedience to law, and contrary to the advantage of the stronger.

Polemarchus briefly supports Socrates, while Cleitophon offers a defence of Thrasymachus: perhaps justice is what the stronger believes to be to his advantage. The small exchange is revealing. Polemarchus has learned something from Socrates and takes his side. He will speak again at the beginning of Book V, while Cleitophon does not speak again. Only a few of those present speak at all, and the principal interlocutors in the later books will be Glaucon and Adeimantus.

Thrasymachus himself makes a different move. A ruler, strictly speaking, does not make a mistake in ruling. A true legislator knows his advantage and legislates accordingly. The argument shifts from a description of how actual regimes work to a standard of what a ruler properly so called does. Thrasymachus takes a page out of Socrates' book. A doctor in the strict sense knows how to cure, a shoemaker how to make shoes. It is by

invoking an analogous standard of expertise that Thrasymachus tries to defend the rule of the stronger.

Socrates asks what follows if ruling is a craft. The Greek word *technē* covers arts and crafts, activities that can be taught through rules or principles. One can explain how to make shoes or practise medicine in a way that one cannot explain where a poet's inspiration comes from. Socrates asks whether politics is a craft of this kind. If so, it can be examined alongside medicine, shoemaking and other activities governed by knowledge.

Each craft, according to Socrates, attends to what falls within its domain. Medicine is concerned with sick or healthy bodies, shoemaking with shoes. As a physician, a doctor heals bodies; making a living is a different matter. A shoemaker as such makes shoes, and a shepherd as such looks after the flock. In each case the craft aims at the good of what it is exercised upon, not at the private benefit of the practitioner. If ruling is a craft, that conclusion bears directly on whose interests the ruler serves.

Thrasymachus responds with a personal attack. Does Socrates have a nurse? She should wipe his nose. This is not how the best interlocutors in Plato conduct an argument. When sophists lose ground, in my experience of the dialogues, they tend either to fall silent or to grow petulant. Reputation matters to men who depend on being paid to speak. Looking foolish in front of the young men is bad for business.

Nevertheless, the reply contains an objection worth hearing. Do not tell me, Thrasymachus says, that the shepherd looks after sheep for the sake of the sheep. He is thinking of his dinner. He looks after them for his own benefit. On this view a practitioner exercises a craft for what he can get from it. As long as the doctor gets paid, one might say, it makes no difference to him whether he cures anyone. Thrasymachus is about to leave. Socrates asks him not to pour out his speech and disappear like an attendant who pours the hot water at the baths. He wants to examine the argument further.

Does the unjust man try to get the better of everybody? Thrasymachus agrees that he does. He wants to outdo both the just and other unjust people and to secure all the good things for himself. In this respect he resembles the hero Thrasymachus admires, an Achilles or a figure with something like Machiavellian *virtù*. He wants to be king of the hill. But Socrates asks whether this is what a person who really knows a craft does. The knowledgeable person wishes to outdo the ignorant, while the ignorant person wishes to outdo everyone.

Consider a modern example. A patient has a heart attack. A cardiologist begins the appropriate treatment. When a second cardiologist arrives and sees that the first is doing what the situation requires, there is no reason to take over. The second has nothing to gain for the patient by outdoing the first. Now suppose the first person is a quack and is doing something that could kill the patient. The competent cardiologist will intervene. The difference has to do with knowledge and with the patient's good, rather than with a wish to assert superiority.

The political analogy follows. Imagine a well-ordered city with a lawful ruler who genuinely knows how to govern. Someone else with political knowledge has no more reason to usurp that ruler than one cardiologist has to displace another who is treating

the patient correctly. If a city is badly governed by people who make foolish laws because they lack knowledge, the person who understands politics has a reason to intervene. The beneficiary should be the city, just as in medicine the beneficiary should be the patient. Practitioners who understand their craft are on the same side. Those without knowledge may seek to outdo experts and non-experts alike, to the detriment of whatever the craft is meant to serve.

At this point Thrasymachus is silenced. There is a wonderful moment at 350d: he blushes. He has been sweating under the questioning. An outsider hoping to sell his skills to the young men of Athens wants to look good in front of them, and here he loses his composure. Socrates has shown, at least, that Thrasymachus cannot carry on the discussion on his own terms. Yet there is a difference between silencing him and refuting him.

When an argument by Socrates seems bad, the first thing to do is read it again. Often it turns out to be better than one initially thought. But there are also genuinely dubious arguments in Plato. The dialogues are put together with remarkable care, and I suspect that many of these weaknesses are deliberate. Sometimes an argument points beyond itself to something else. Sometimes, more interestingly, its weakness makes room for the next stage of the inquiry.

By the end of Book I, Socrates has interrupted three accounts of justice. Cephalus and Polemarchus are metics, resident foreigners. Thrasymachus is a visiting teacher of rhetoric. In Book II, Glaucon and Adeimantus, talented young Athenians who might go into politics, renew the argument. The struggle over who will educate them is central to the *Republic*. Will their educator be Thrasymachus or Socrates?

On my reading, Socrates must defeat Thrasymachus without making the question appear settled. The young men must be moved to take up the challenge in a stronger form. Glaucon and Adeimantus are the real audience of the encounter. Thrasymachus' defeat makes room for their more demanding account of injustice and for a fuller inquiry into justice and virtue. Socrates wins the opportunity to educate them by arousing their curiosity about the question that Book I leaves open.